

Divisions within Islam Sunnis

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** NSROCK FAGs destroyed the ITINE

Personal and tribal rivalries posed such obstacles to the choice of A succerssor that there was genuine threat of civil war.

only

desperate act of acclaiming one of the number of their number khalifah or Successor to the Prophet on the part of his closest companions averted a disaster.

the man chosen was Abu Bakr, an intimate associate of Muhammad and one of the early prominent converts from Makkah.

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He was already old and after a reign of two years. passing on his authority to the aple and fiery khalifahe, Umar ibn al-khattab, the most brilliant

the rightly guided khalifahs, as the first successors to muhamad ere known.

Umar was murdered by an

in 644 and was succeeded by another.

Uthman, has successor, was murdered by a group of dissidents who accused him of corrupt rule, and his successor, the last of the rightly guided Khalifahs, Ali ibn Abi Talib, the cousin and

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law of Muhammad.

he

was never firmly established in power and from the beginning

his claims to rule were contested by a party who suspected him of complicity in the murder of 'Uthman.

It is this Ali that the Shi'ahs look back to as the

the rightful

ruler.

mor 2 On that later.

Ali lost, after a protracted struggle, to Mu'awiyah who derived his

support from Syrian tribesmen. because of this he set

up his capital in Damascus rather than Madinah.

In spite of the violence and unrest that characterized the period. Muslims have always looked back to the pious caliphate as

the time of Islam's greatest purity and glory.

The khalifahs themselves are among the most revered figures of Islamic history.

the accomplishments of the pious khalifahs were considerable.

first: of all they succeeded in maintaining the unity of the community in spite of break-away attempts by some Bedouin groups who considered their loyalty to have been to Muhammad and to have been dissolved with his death.

second. they laid the foundations of a polity which kept the Arab armies intact in their camp cities and which provided means of governing the new territories

third, and most important, were the great conquests themselves beginning under Rāḡ. In rapid succession the rich provinces of Syria, Iraq, Palestine and Egypt came under Muslim control. the great Sassanian Empire was brought down

641 and the whole

Iranian plateau was added to Muslim territories.

All the land which the Muslims overran in their first great expansion,

with the exception of Spain and portions of Central

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Asia, has remained under Islamic control to this day.

today the greatest number of Muslims live outside the regions taken in the earliest conquests.

one of the later waves of expansion brought the faith to India in a decisive way, and although Muslims have never been the majority there, the establishment of the Sultanate of Delhi in 1192 until 1837 they were rulers of a vast Indian Empire.

at present there are over 160 million Muslims found in India and Pakistan.

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still later wave of growth introduced Islam to the Indonesian archipelago through the agency of traders and wandering mystics by the 12th century.

in the 15th cent. the first important Muslim sultanate took form and today the majority of Indonesians, millions are Muslims.

more than 100

The Turks who began to enter Islamic territories and the service of the rulers in large numbers in the 10th cent, subdued the vast region of Anatolia and Asia Minor for Islam.

The Saljuq Turks were the first to establish themselves but

eventually gave way to the Ottomans who at last overthrew Christian power in Constantinople in 1453 and drove their armies from Eastern Europe.

at the height of their strength the Ottomans dominated the Balkan countries and sent an army to the gates of Vienna as late 1693.

thus was another important region added to the domain of

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Islam, and the permanent influence of Islam on European soil established.

1 a tradition popularly ascribed to the Prophet, Muhammad is alleged to have said: "my community will divide into seventy-three sects of which only one is correct."

in fact. Islamic history has produced vastly more sectarian groupings than the traditional number of 73.

a catalogue of the whole number of sects is impossible to give but on schism is of such importance that it must be discussed.

(sometimes, and in possibly erroneously, called orthodox") and

Sunn muslims speak of themselves as "the people of established custom and of the (genuine) community.

this terminology carries

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connotation of positive judgement

and amounts to a claim to be the living representatives and bearers of true Islam, of the practices, beliefs and that have consistently characterized the

expressions

majority of the

community throughout its history.

another way of explaining the Sunnis is to say that they see themselves as the

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tronairsts of the community.

they claim to maintain the ways established by pious men of

They **do** not see any necessity of **having** a direct descendent

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Teader

«xousands can **read-the-poodies Witir** : religious authority :

Such a concept of community provides means for expanding guidance to meet changed needs and conditions without compromising the fundamental belief in revelation.

date their origins from, at latest, the death of Muhammad and perhaps even earlier.

The word Shi'ah means and the group got its name from its

the the cousin and son-in-law of Muhammad, in the early struggles for leadership in the community.

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LI PASUCCESSIT

of all Muhammad's family Ali was clearly the most qualified. the Shi'ah justified their position by citing traditions from Muhammad and even the Qur'an verses where the Prophet is said to have designated

Ali as his successor thus they opposed the election of the first three khalifas, whom to this day the Shi'ah consider usurpers: and after the short and unsettled reign of Ali, which was brought to an end by his death in 661, they took up the cause of his son, a khalifa

SE Hasan and Husayn, as legitimate claimants to the leadership in Arabic the word for leadership is "imamah" the exclusive right to the imamah for Muhammad's family has been a cardinal Shi'ah doctrine thru history.

killed in pitiable circumstances in southern Iraq.

This tragic event occurred on the tenth day of the month of Muharram in A.H. 61 "agedy .

and #
titled

thought...
gust

has aduced, the Elements Of Sorrow, Suffering, of the cried? and of pious sacrifice into the Shi'i strain of religious expression.

during the Muharram celebrations each year the story of Husayn is repeated by preachers and storytellers and dramatized in passion plays.

the Shi'i march in processions where they exhibit symbols of the slain martyr while beating their breasts and wailing of

engaging in self inflicted flagellation, cutting their heads, etc

The occasion is one of great grief that purges the souls of the worshipers while at the same time it is a cause for rejoicing in the salvation and guidance which Husayn has bestowed on the faithful.

noble self-sacrifice

this passion motif is not tied

just to

Husayn

rather Shi'ah believe that all of their imams and other members of the holy family including the Prophet himself have suffered martyrdom at the hands of unjust men.

In the passion plays, which often last for days, the history of these martyrdoms is traced.

According to the Shi'ah most of the imams have died by

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poison, usually administered at the instigation of the khalifahs who usurped the imam's rightful place to rule.

An Imam means leader and can refer in Sunni circles to especially learned men as in the case of the founders of the four Sunni schools of law, or certain other distinguished individuals.

Among the Shi'ah the word has a meaning far beyond the usual one.

Upon Muhammad's death the Shi'ah believe that not only his function as ruler but also his role as religious guide devolved upon his descendants beginning with Ali.

to

The series of visible imams, living openly in the world came to an end with the mysterious disappearance of the last imam.

for

at a time the imam retained contact with his followers through representatives who had direct access to him. but soon even this was broken off.

the shima

"hidden" until he MCDAN

Come again at the End DE.TIME as the final bang to establish INA:

*Kingdom of God

learned men of the Shi'ah community act as interpreters of the divine will for the Imam constitutes a living source of guidance

In the world at all times.. the importance of the doctrine is

shown in the saying: "He who dies without knowing the Imam of the

age dies in unbelief.

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The precise nature of the imam is understood differently by the numerous sects, but the belief in the immamah is common to them all and is their distinguishing characteristic.

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present

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MONIK Again more experiences the full reality of

should the imam ever be withdrawn, the entire order of reality would literally collapse because of the absence of its essential principle.

this view is almost precisely parallel to the Sufi understanding of the Qutb or great saint around whom the whole order of reality turns.

At the other extreme of Shi'ah opinion the imam is considered only to be inspired or divinely led, as the Prophet himself was.

between the two extremes stand the Companions who hold a kind of doctrine of metempsychosis with respect to the imams.

according to this understanding a spark of the eternal divine Wisdom was implanted in Muhammad and upon his death was transplanted into Ali and from thence into the series of his descendants whom God had chosen.

thus though there is an element of the divine in each of the imams,

there is not a complete indwelling as the more extreme ghulat believe.

whichever is the case, the imam in Shi'ite thinking has radical implications for the understanding of religious authority, for so long as the imam is accessible either personally or through his representatives in the form of a learned man, there is a living source of guidance always at hand.

There are some differences among the Shi'ah also about the number of imams and their identity.

there

are those who accept a series of seven and those who accept a series of twelve.

they are called

they recognize)
"Twelvers")

and

OF Ismailis (after the last imam
DF Ithna Ashariyah (Arabic for

generally speaking, the seveners have been more radical in
their views than the Twelvers.

for a great part of Islamic history the seveners existed
secret societies which, in the effort to spread their creed
among Muslims, engaged in revolutionary activities against
established rulers and states, often, as in the case of the
famous Assassins, using terrorism as one of their methods.

The seveners gained support with the rise of the Fatimi
dynasty of Egypt (969-1174) whose rulers reckoned themselves in
the line of descent from Muhammad ibn Ismail, the last imam of
the seveners.

it was

one of the most brilliant eras of Islamic history with
the founding of modern Cairo, the establishment of the famous
al-Azhar univ. and many other feats.

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there are numerous sub groups that continue to flourish at
the present time, among which are included the

→ and the Nusayris of Syria. most famous 19
the followers of the Agha Khan, the majority of whom are found in
India and the areas around the Indian Ocean.

these follow an esoteric teaching which one must be initiated
in to understand. this is an elaborate philosophy influenced by
Neo-platonism and Gnosticism.

renowned by NGO

Boostici

they believe that everything in the external world represents
on a small scale the realities of a spiritual and invisible
world.

penetration beyond the external to knowledge of the spiritual
realities is the aim of the teaching.

Numero,

sevenem

they are spread over a great area with the majority
concentrated

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where they are more than half the

population, and team, and in the Indian subcontinent".

Twelver Shi'ism had a great boost when in the 16th cent. the Fawx dynasty in Iran chose to make it the official religion of the state.

It has continued this favored status and Iran is now the stronghold of the group.

Altho the principle Shi'i shrines are located at Najaf and Karbala in Iraq (the burial places of Ali and Husayn) Iran also

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has holy places and centers of pilgrimage in Mashhad and Cum where great theological schools maintain the tradition / Shi'i learning and teaching.

The Shi'ah are distinguished from the Sunni in other ways than just the doctrine of the imam.

There is a separate and distinct Shi'i fiqh which recognized completely different authorities from those of the four 'orthodox' Sunni schools.

The rules of law differentiating Shi'ah and Sunni are small being limited for the most part to minor details.

The greatest variation arises in jurisprudential theory because of the preponderating role of the imam in Shi'i thinking and the continued Shi'i espousal of Ijtihad.

The Shi'ah also have their own distinctive collections of traditions such as the book entitled Al-Kafi (the Sufficient One) by al-Kulayni (d. 939) and others.

ssamer as the

another important difference is in the area of theology.

On the whole the Shi'ah have inclined im

A

far more

rationalistic direction than has Sunni Islam.

Much of the doctrine of the Mu'tazilah was survived among the their theological method they show a preference

Shi'ah. and

for rational argument above traditionalist

views.

This inclination to rationalism accounts in large part for the great richness in philosophy, theology and speculative science

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generally among the Shi'ah.

·WEEN SII alt and

this can happen especially at the time of the Muharram celebrations when Shi 1 fervor is at it highest.

there has, however, been a determined effort to play down the differences and divisive effect of religious differences in light of the outside pressures of the west and of other ideologies.

Fundamentalist Islam

first a disclaimer. The Muslims don't even know the word fundamentalist and don't think of themselves that way.

War

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I
n

this group is known as

which means holy

these believe that they will eventually take over the world for Islam.

by the 10th century Cairo was the center for art and learning. the crusaders ended that but the tide has turned again.

Egypt under Nasser and Sadat tried to become modern state with separation of religion and secular interests.

the jihad wanted
separation and-

See Egypt as an Islamic state without any
Jawb

Islamic.

Jihad converts tend to be well educated, young and from lower middle classes -rural background, and high achievers who are dissatisfied and easily converted to this view.

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Even the University of Cairo is turning back to laws including dress codes for women, makeshift mosques in the school.

16 years ago only 10% of the women in Cairo wore the veil, now 70% have gone back to wearing it.

Ibn.

Nasser crushed militant Muslims and in 1967 led Egypt into a war with Israel which lasted 6 days and was a devastating loss for Egypt.

this was seen by conservative Muslims as the judgement of Allah.

Sadat gave the public relations appearance of a devout Muslim but it was a convenient cloak to keep the people happy.

He wanted Egypt to be in the mode of a western state and

invited in the west. he brought in hotels and industry but nothing really important which could help the general populace.

rather, his friends got rich and it became clear he was not really caring for the people.

under Sedat Egypt became 2 nations:

1. the rich and elite imitating the west and
2. the poor who could not even be fed enough. Cairo had 14 million people, mostly poor

Islam became thier voice and most of the Jihad are young and militant who have been nurtured on horror stories of the west

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In 1977 there was a riot in CAiro-Sedat had to back down made peace with Israel.

so he

he did this because of a promise of the U. S. to give aid to the economy.

he signed his own death warrent.

Sedat cracked down on protest of the Camp David accord and arrested thousands. imprisoned and tortured them.

when Jihad leader, Mohammad, was arrested it sealed Sedat's fate. The leader" brother and the Jihad were responsible for Sedat s death

Mohammed was arrested again and is still in prison.

western culture is still going strong with gambling, dancing. etc. ie, the seedier things of western culture.

Sedat's successor, Hosni Mubarak, walks a tight rope. tries to be a pious muslim.

In Jan. 1987 Jihad tried to overthrow his government. Were

many

arrested but the underground is growing and plotting.

e enemy. One

as the Idea

comment by a Jihad leader is that Islam is a tree that feeds on blood. It will rule the world.

In Egypt the Jihad is a Sunni-movement but in Lebenon it is Shah and much more zealous.

Lebenon

Israel has been shelling border towns

of Lebonon for years

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it took on the Christian forces and won they hold at least half of Beirut.

Iran's

influence is seen everywhere.

The Green Line" is the area separating Christian and Moslem sectors and is the most dangerous area in Beirut. than Amal.

S means the party of God" and is much more fanatical they want an Islamic republic like Iran. These are the ones who are taking hostages and who killed the 250 Marines in a suicide mission.

They are also the ones who hijacked a TWA and killed american passengers.

in 1985.

their battle cry is "Allah Akbar" God is Great.

they want a world Islamic republic and believe one day they will have it.